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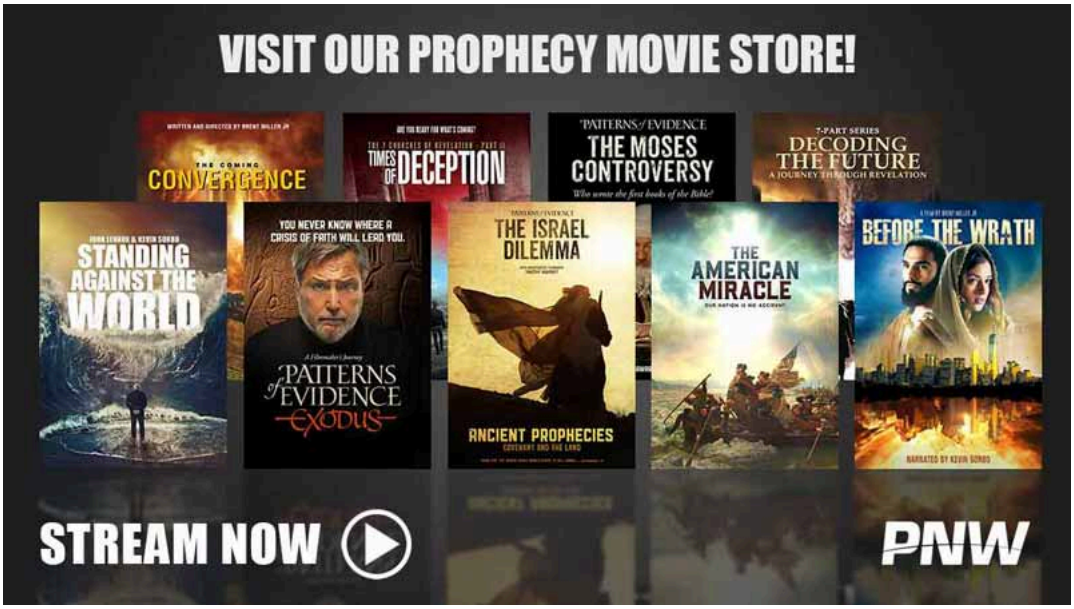

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ARTICLE

The Battle Over Zionism: Christians Divided As Anti-Israel Extremism Rises

BY PNW STAFF MARCH 16, 2026

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The battle over Zionism is no longer confined to the Middle East. It is now raging in Western cities, online platforms, and even inside churches. On one side are radical anti-Zionist movements openly aligning themselves with terrorist organizations and hostile regimes. On the other are Christians wrestling with a deeply theological question: what does the Bible actually say about Israel?

The divide is growing sharper by the day.

A Movement That Has Shed Any Mask

The ugliness of the modern anti-Zionist movement was on full display recently in New York City during demonstrations marking Al Quds Day--an annual anti-Israel rally created in 1979 by Iran's revolutionary regime under Ruhollah Khomeini.

The event this year came at a moment of intense global tension, as Israel and the United States confront the regime in Iran and its network of proxy militias. Rather than condemn terrorism or call for peace, demonstrators openly sided with forces seeking Israel's destruction.

Speakers praised the so-called "resistance," applauding Hamas and Hezbollah. Flags of Palestinian Islamic Jihad were waved. Chants rang out declaring "Death to America" and "Death to Israel." Others shouted slogans glorifying the October 7 attacks that stunned the world.

Perhaps most disturbing were the grotesque accusations hurled at Jewish counter-protesters. Demonstrators shouted that Jews "eat babies" and "rape children," resurrecting the medieval blood libel that fueled pogroms and mass killings across Europe for centuries.

This is not a fringe misunderstanding of Zionism.

It is open, unapologetic hatred.

At its core, much of the modern anti-Zionist movement appears willing to support anyone--terrorist groups, authoritarian regimes, or violent extremists--so long as they are fighting Israel. In that sense, the ideology has become less about Palestinian rights and more about opposition to the very existence of the Jewish state.

That is precisely what Zionism actually addresses.

As Ted Cruz recently explained in an interview, Zionism simply affirms that the Jewish people have the right to exist in their historic homeland. The modern state of Israel was established after the horrors of the Holocaust and the murder of six million Jews by Nazi Germany.

The idea that the Jewish people should have one secure homeland after centuries of persecution was once widely accepted across the political spectrum.

Today, however, it is being fiercely contested.

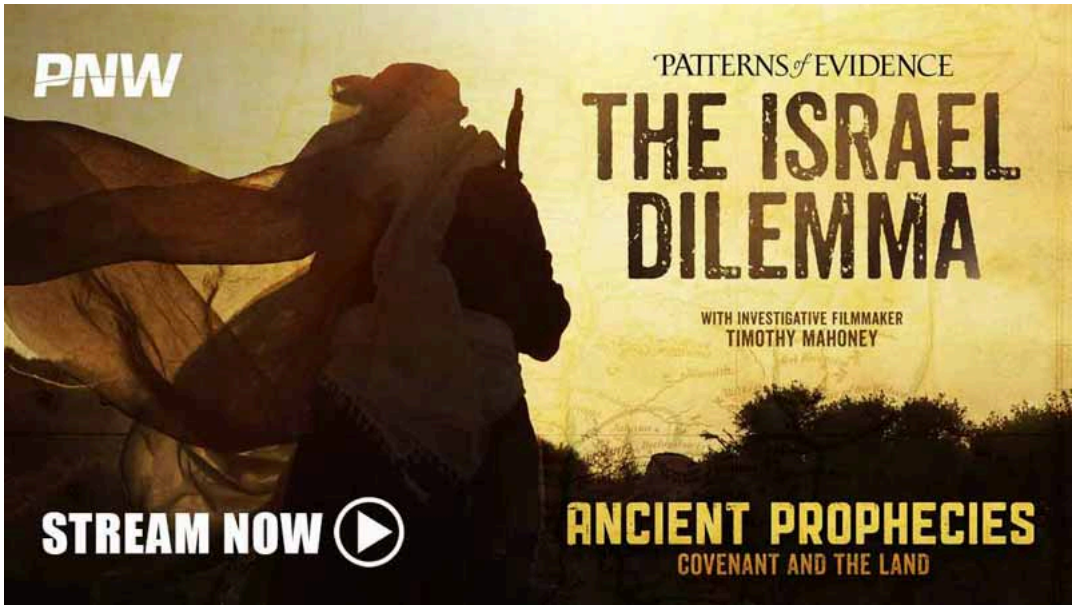
A Controversy Reaches the Trump Religious Commission

The same tensions are now spilling into the heart of American political institutions.

The Trump administration's Religious Liberties Commission was rocked this week by another resignation tied to the Israel debate. Sameerah Munshi, a Muslim member of an advisory board connected to the commission, stepped down while accusing the body of being overtaken by what she described as a "Zionist political agenda."

Munshi said her resignation was intended to protest the earlier dismissal of commissioner Carrie Prejean Boller. Boller had been removed after using a hearing on antisemitism to argue that her Catholic faith compelled her to oppose Israel and Zionism.

The controversy intensified when Boller confronted Jewish witnesses who had survived the October 7 terror attacks, challenging them during testimony about antisemitism. The exchange sparked outrage from Jewish organizations and members of the administration.



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Munshi publicly defended Boller and later resigned herself, also criticizing the U.S. military confrontation with Iran and claiming it was being conducted "at the urging of a genocidal state"--a direct reference to Israel.

The episode revealed just how deeply the Israel debate has penetrated American politics, even in forums intended to address religious freedom.

It also highlighted the growing influence of commentators such as Candace Owens, whom both Boller and Munshi have cited favorably despite her increasing embrace of controversial claims about Israel and global Jewish influence.

A Growing Division Inside Christianity

The anti-Zionist movement outside the church is one battle. Inside Christianity, another debate is unfolding.

Christians themselves are divided over what it means to be a Christian Zionist.

For millions of believers--particularly within Evangelical traditions--support for Israel is rooted in theology rather than politics. They believe the promises God made to the Jewish people in the Hebrew Scriptures remain valid today.

This belief rejects what theologians call replacement theology, the idea that the Christian church has replaced Israel in God's covenant plan. Many Evangelicals see that doctrine as both biblically flawed and historically dangerous, pointing to centuries when it was used to justify antisemitism.

Christian Zionism, at its core, simply holds that God keeps His promises.

Scripture repeatedly describes God's covenant with Israel as everlasting. Passages throughout the Bible speak of Zion--Jerusalem--as central to God's unfolding story. For believers who take those promises literally, supporting Israel's existence is not merely a geopolitical preference; it is an affirmation that God's word is trustworthy.

But the label itself can be misunderstood.

Being a Christian Zionist does not mean endorsing every decision of the Israeli government or ignoring the suffering of innocent people in the region. The Bible calls believers to justice, mercy, and humility toward all.

At the same time, supporters argue that denying Israel's right to exist goes far beyond legitimate criticism of policy.

It crosses into something far darker.

Conservative Allies Now Divided

What makes the moment even more striking is that some of the sharpest disputes are now emerging within the conservative and Christian worlds themselves.

The earlier dismissal of Carrie Prejean Boller already exposed tensions within conservative faith circles. But the controversy has only deepened as prominent commentators increasingly attack Israel and the pro-Israel movement.

Influential media figures such as Tucker Carlson and Candace Owens have launched repeated critiques of Israel and of the broader pro-Israel coalition in the United States.

Interestingly, many of the most visible critics come from Catholic backgrounds.

Historically, segments of Catholic theology have been more open to replacement theology than Evangelical traditions. While the modern Catholic Church strongly rejects antisemitism, theological disagreements about Israel's continuing role in biblical prophecy remain.

Those doctrinal differences explain why conservatives who agree on nearly every political issue--from economics to cultural battles--can find themselves fiercely divided over Israel.

For Evangelical Christians, the Jewish people remain central to God's covenant story. For others, the modern state of Israel is simply another nation among many.

The result is a fracture that is unlikely to disappear anytime soon.

The Debate Isn't Going Away

What is clear is that the battle over Zionism will only intensify.

Outside the church, anti-Zionist activism is becoming increasingly radicalized, openly celebrating organizations committed to Israel's destruction.

Inside the church, believers are wrestling with profound theological questions about scripture, covenant, and the future of God's promises.

For Christians who support Israel, the issue ultimately comes down to trust: if God's promises to Israel can be erased, what does that say about His promises to anyone else?

For critics, the debate is about how faith should intersect with modern geopolitics.

Either way, the divide is now impossible to ignore.

The battle over Zionism has become not just a political conflict, but a spiritual one--and it is reshaping alliances in ways few anticipated only a few years ago.

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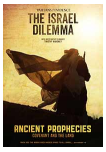

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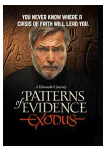

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